

Top secret

The word “code” refers to a set of rules. Coders use these rules to tell computers what to do. However, codes can also be used to keep secrets. Throughout history, people have created codes to hide what a message says. A coded message can only be read if you know the secret rules to decode it.

Hail, Caesar!

Julius Caesar’s code was very simple, but it worked for centuries. Most of his enemies could not read very well, so they thought he was writing his messages in a foreign language.



Polybius Square

The Greek historian Polybius worked for the Romans. He created a new code for their armies, using a square grid which matched each letter in the Greek alphabet to a pair of numbers. People with the same square could exchange messages written only in numbers.

Scytale

The Ancient Greeks of Sparta would scramble their messages by writing them on leather or parchment wrapped around a rod or stick. Then they added extra letters, so when the message was unwrapped from the rod, it became a meaningless jumble.

Caesar shift

The Roman general and emperor Julius Caesar swapped each letter in his secret messages with a different one. Every letter moved a set number of spaces forward in the alphabet, so in a one-shift code, “A” would become “B.”

Alberti formula

In 1467, the Italian architect Leon Alberti invented a disk with two wheels, which could be rotated to swap one letter in a message for another. To swap the letters back and decode the message, you needed to know how the two disks had been rotated.